

ILIKEITDEEP · A GUIDED JOURNAL

What They Knew

A Journal for Breaking Generational Cycles



printable pdf · 18 guided questions · for cycle breakers

WELCOME

Before You Begin



Every family passes things down. Recipes and eye colors —
but also silences, tempers, secrets, and survival habits
that stopped serving anyone generations ago.

You picked up this journal because you're the one
who's decided some of it ends with you.

That makes you the cycle breaker — the hardest and most
important job in a family tree. These pages will help you
see the patterns, understand where they came from,
and choose, on purpose, what gets passed forward.

If the roots run into deep trauma, a therapist is a powerful
partner for this work. Cycle breaking is heavy lifting.

STARTING POINT

The Family Weather



Describe the emotional weather of the home you grew up in — the moods, the rules nobody said out loud, what it felt like to walk in the door.

PART ONE

Seeing the Pattern



*You can't break what you can't see. Look
closely — and gently.*

What patterns run through your family — in anger, money, silence, drinking, love, or leaving?



What topics were forbidden in your family? What happened when someone got close to them?



*What did the adults around you do with their pain —
and where did it land?*



What family 'rules' did you absorb without anyone teaching them out loud?



Which pattern have you caught yourself repeating, even though you swore you never would?



What secrets shaped your family that everyone knew and no one named?



PART TWO

Understanding Where It Came From



*Understanding isn't excusing. It's finding the
beginning of the thread.*

What do you know about what your parents survived — and what they were never taught?



What did your grandparents' era demand of them, and what did that cost the family emotionally?



*Which behaviors in your family started as protection
— and then outlived the danger?*



What did the people who hurt you never get for themselves — help, softness, safety, truth?



*What's one pattern you can hold with both hands:
'this explains it' AND 'this doesn't excuse it'?*



If your family's pain could talk, what would it say it needed all along?



PART THREE

Ending It With You



• *You're not betraying your family by healing.* •
• *You're completing something they couldn't.* •

What specifically ends with you? Write it like a declaration.



What are you doing differently already — even in small ways nobody else notices?



What does breaking the cycle cost you — guilt, distance, being called 'too sensitive'? Name the price you're paying.



What do you want the next generation — your kids, nieces, or younger you's — to inherit instead?



What good DID your family pass down that you want to keep and grow?



Write a note to the future generations of your family. Tell them what you did for them.



When the Old Pattern Knocks



Cycles show up mid-argument, mid-holiday, mid-sentence. Check your interruptions.

- ☐ Pause before reacting — the cycle lives in the reflex
- ☐ Ask: is this my voice or the house I grew up in?
- ☐ Lower my volume when the old script says raise it
- ☐ Say the thing my family never said: 'I'm sorry' or 'I was wrong'
- ☐ Let a child's feelings exist without fixing or silencing them
- ☐ Step outside instead of slamming inward
- ☐ Break a silence with one honest sentence
- ☐ Choose repair within 24 hours of a rupture
- ☐ Rest without guilt — burnout was a family heirloom too
- ☐ Remind myself: awkward and new beats comfortable and harmful

BONUS · KEEP THIS PAGE

Cycles I've Already Broken



*Every time you chose differently than what was modeled — log it.
This page is your family tree growing a new branch.*

























BEFORE YOU CLOSE THIS JOURNAL

A Note, From One Human to Another



Somewhere down the line, someone in your family
will live freer because of choices they'll never know
you made. That's what cycle breaking is —
love, sent forward, unsigned.

Be patient with yourself when the old patterns flare.
You're doing something with no map and no example.
It ends with you. And something better begins there too.



*Generations of patterns. One decision.
Yours.*



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